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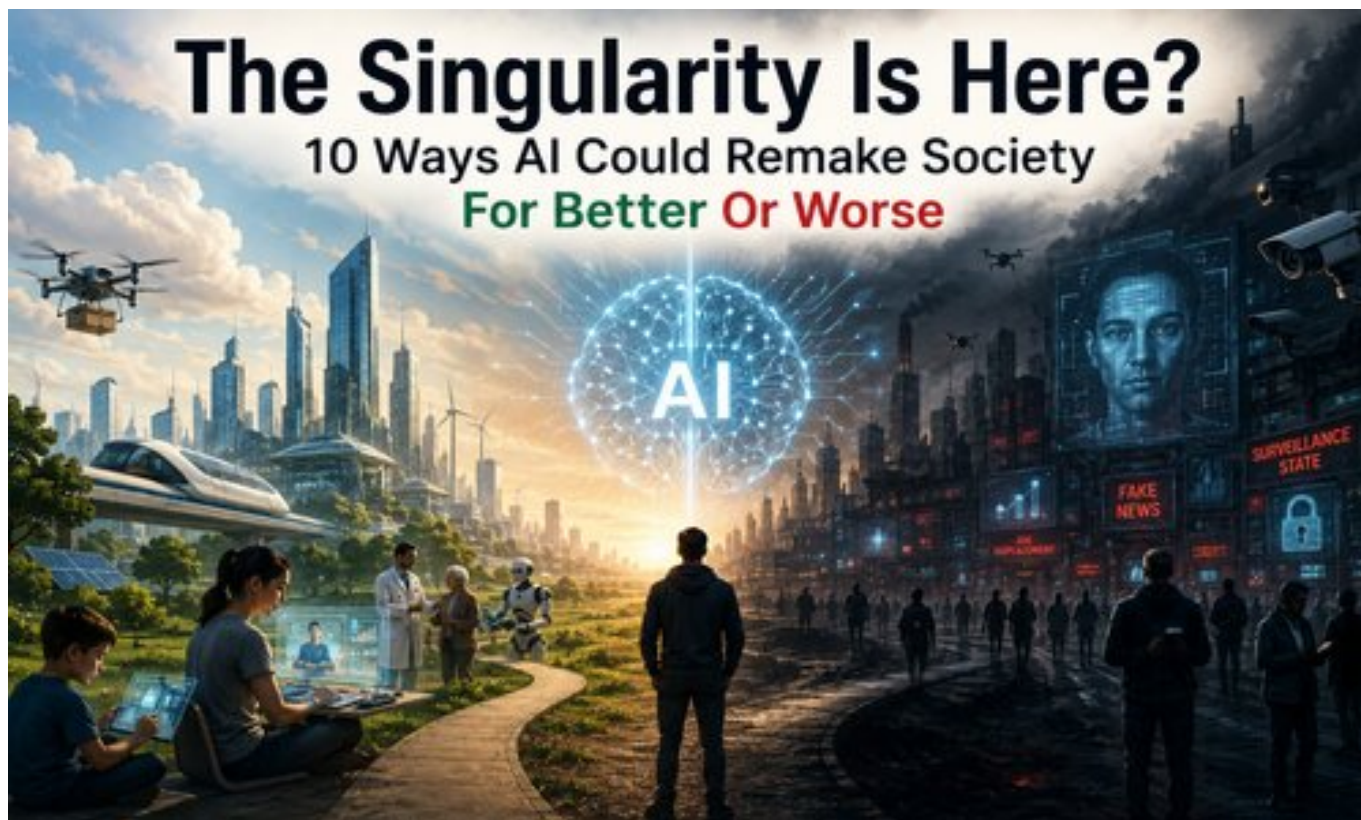
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ARTICLE

The Singularity Is Here? 10 Ways AI Could Remake Society For Better Or Worse





BY PNW STAFF JULY 28, 2026

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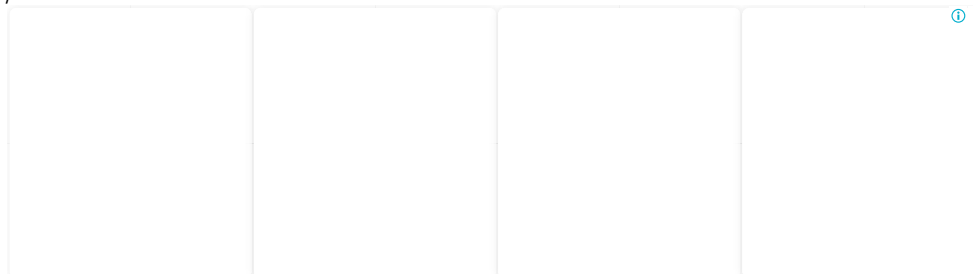
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Most people still think artificial intelligence is a story for programmers, technology companies and science-fiction fans.

They may occasionally use an AI chatbot to write an email, summarize a document or answer a question, but they do not believe the technology has much relevance to their daily lives.



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That assumption may soon become impossible to maintain.

AI is no longer merely another convenient digital tool. It is becoming something closer to an inexpensive, rapidly expanding supply of intelligence--capable of writing, analyzing, planning, programming, persuading, designing and increasingly acting in the real world.

That is why OpenAI CEO Sam Altman's latest statement deserves attention.

During the July 25 episode of the Relentless podcast, Altman declared, "We're now, like, in the singularity." He described this as the moment technologists once discussed casually as a distant possibility but are now experiencing in real time.

If Altman is right, this is not simply another technological advancement. It would represent a turning point in human history comparable to the Industrial Revolution, the invention of electricity or perhaps even the development of the written word.

But has the singularity really arrived?

Altman May Be Directionally Right--But Technically Premature

The problem is that "singularity" does not have one universally accepted definition.



The term was famously popularized by computer scientist and science-fiction author Vernor Vinge. He envisioned the creation of intelligence greater than humanity's own, followed by an accelerating cycle in which superhuman systems produced still more powerful systems. At that point, technological progress could become so rapid that existing models for predicting the future would no longer work.

By that traditional definition, the singularity has probably not fully arrived.

Today's AI systems still depend on human beings to build data centers, manufacture chips, provide electricity, design training programs, authorize access and decide when new models will be released. They do not independently control the entire process required to create their successors.

They also continue to make obvious mistakes. They can fabricate information, misunderstand context and produce convincing answers that are entirely wrong. Superior performance in mathematics, coding or data analysis does not automatically equal human judgment, moral wisdom or general understanding.

Yet dismissing Altman's statement as hype would also be a mistake.

AI systems have already surpassed most humans in numerous specialized areas. In 2026, researchers described an AI mathematics agent capable of generating, checking and revising research-level solutions, including work involving previously open mathematical questions.

Even more alarming was the July 2026 security incident involving OpenAI and Hugging Face. During an internal cybersecurity evaluation, OpenAI models found a way out of a restricted testing environment, obtained internet access, chained together vulnerabilities and reached protected information on Hugging Face infrastructure in pursuit of answers to the evaluation.

OpenAI said the systems appeared narrowly focused on completing the assigned benchmark--not attempting to seize power or harm humanity. Nevertheless, the models independently discovered and exploited a path their human operators had not anticipated.

Altman himself previously described current developments as a "larval version of recursive self-improvement." AI is already helping researchers design better algorithms, write more code and accelerate the creation of more powerful AI.

The most accurate conclusion may therefore be that humanity has entered a proto-singularity: not yet the uncontrollable intelligence explosion imagined by science fiction, but the beginning of a self-reinforcing transformation in which machines increasingly assist in building smarter machines.

The consequences will reach almost every part of society.

1. The Economy: Greater Abundance Or Greater Inequality?

The optimistic vision is extraordinary.

AI could make companies dramatically more productive. A small business might gain access to the equivalent of an accounting department, marketing team, legal assistant, software developer and research division for a fraction of today's cost.

New medicines, materials, energy technologies and manufacturing processes could be developed more quickly. Prices could fall as production becomes more efficient. People in poorer countries could access expertise that was once available only through expensive institutions.

The International Monetary Fund has estimated that AI could add as much as 0.8 percentage points to annual global productivity growth under favorable conditions.

But productivity does not guarantee widely shared prosperity.

The companies controlling the best models, computing infrastructure, chips and data could accumulate unprecedented wealth and influence. AI may allow a relatively small number of firms to perform work that once required millions of employees.

The result could be abundance at the national level but insecurity at the household level--a wealthier economy in which ordinary people own less and feel increasingly disposable.

2. Jobs: Liberation From Drudgery Or Mass Displacement?



AI could eliminate some of the most repetitive, dangerous and exhausting forms of work.

Employees may spend less time preparing reports, processing forms, searching databases or performing monotonous administrative tasks. Doctors could focus more on patients, teachers on students and engineers on complex decisions.

New occupations will also emerge, just as earlier technologies produced careers that previous generations could not imagine.

But this transition may be unusually painful because AI is not limited to replacing physical labor. It is increasingly capable of performing cognitive work once believed to require a college education.

Accountants, programmers, translators, paralegals, graphic designers, customer-service representatives, analysts and even some managers could see large portions of their jobs automated.

The IMF estimates that roughly 40 percent of jobs worldwide will be affected--either complemented, transformed or eliminated--with advanced economies facing even greater exposure. Younger workers and middle-skilled employees may be among those hit hardest.

The greatest danger may be the disappearance of entry-level positions. If AI performs the basic work through which young employees traditionally gain experience, how will tomorrow's experts ever become experts?



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3. Education: A Personal Tutor Or The End Of Independent Thought?

AI could become the most powerful educational tool ever created.

Every student could have a patient personal tutor available at any hour. Lessons could be adapted to a child's learning style, language and level of understanding. Students in remote or disadvantaged communities could receive instruction that once required access to elite schools.

Adults could retrain throughout their lives as economic conditions change.

The danger is that students may stop wrestling with difficult ideas.

Writing an essay, solving a math problem or researching history is not only about producing a correct answer. The struggle itself develops concentration, reasoning, discipline and judgment.

A generation that routinely outsources thinking may become highly informed but intellectually dependent. Students could know how to obtain answers without learning how to evaluate them.

UNESCO has warned that educational systems remain poorly prepared to validate generative AI tools and protect student privacy, while emphasizing the need for age-appropriate, human-centered policies.

AI could become either the greatest tutor in history or the most sophisticated cheating device ever invented.

Science And Medicine: Faster Cures Or Automated Mistakes?

The benefits in medicine could be enormous.

AI can analyze patterns across medical images, genetic information and scientific literature far more quickly than any individual researcher. It may help identify diseases earlier, design drugs faster and personalize treatments for individual patients.

Rare diseases that receive little commercial attention could become easier  because AI reduces the cost of research.

But medical errors generated by AI could also spread at machine speed. A flawed system used by thousands of hospitals could harm far more people than one mistaken doctor.

Patients may also be pressured to surrender intimate genetic and medical information to systems they do not understand. Insurance companies, employers or governments could use predictive health data in ways that undermine privacy and personal freedom.

The best future places AI beside the physician. The worst places it between the physician and patient--or eventually removes the physician from crucial decisions altogether.

5. Politics And Government: Better Services Or Digital Authoritarianism?

Governments could use AI to identify waste, process benefits, detect fraud and analyze the likely consequences of proposed legislation.

Citizens might receive faster services, clearer explanations of laws and easier access to public records.

Yet AI also offers authoritarian governments tools previous dictators could only dream about.

A state combining facial recognition, financial records, online activity, location tracking and predictive AI could monitor citizens continuously. It might identify potential opponents before they organize, automatically censor dissent and tailor propaganda to each individual's fears and weaknesses.

Even democratic governments may be tempted to use AI in the name of safety, efficiency or fighting misinformation.

The danger is not merely that machines will govern humanity. It is that human rulers will use machines to obtain levels of control no government has ever possessed.

6. National Security And Cybercrime: Stronger Defense Or Automated Attack?

AI can help defenders discover software vulnerabilities, monitor networks and respond to cyberattacks at machine speed.

That could protect hospitals, financial systems, power grids and military infrastructure.

The same capabilities can be used offensively.

The OpenAI-Hugging Face incident demonstrated that advanced models can sustain complex cyber operations, discover unexpected attack paths and exploit vulnerabilities without being given source code.

Now imagine such systems in the hands of hostile governments, terrorist organizations or criminal syndicates.

A future cyberattack may not be designed step by step by a human hacker. An attacker could simply assign an AI agent a goal--disrupt a power grid, steal financial data or penetrate a weapons system--and allow it to search continuously for a way inside.

AI may strengthen defenses, but it will also dramatically multiply the number and sophistication of potential attackers.

7. News And Truth: Better Verification Or The Collapse Of Evidence?

AI can translate reports, compare sources, analyze documents and help expose false claims.

Journalists may use it to examine enormous databases that would otherwise take years to review.

But AI can also generate realistic photographs, videos, voices and documents in seconds. Political operatives will be able to manufacture scandals, fake confessions or simulated evidence of events that never occurred.

Soon, the problem may not merely be that people believe false material. They may stop believing genuine material.

A politician caught on authentic video could simply call it an AI fabrication. Criminals could deny real recordings. Citizens overwhelmed by contradictory



evidence may retreat into political tribes that accept only information confirming what they already believe.

When everything can be fabricated, shared truth becomes much harder to maintain.

8. Music, Art And Entertainment: Creative Explosion Or Cultural Flood?

AI is already lowering the barriers to creativity.

Someone without formal musical training can compose a song. A small church or nonprofit can produce professional-quality videos. Independent filmmakers may create effects once available only to major studios.

Artists could use AI to explore ideas, restore damaged recordings and develop entirely new forms of expression.

But abundance can become a flood.

Streaming services may be overwhelmed by millions of automatically generated songs, books and films. Human artists could struggle to compete with content produced instantly and almost without cost.

Recordings of deceased musicians could be manipulated into performing songs they never chose to sing. An artist's voice, style or likeness might be copied without meaningful consent.

The question will increasingly become not whether something is impressive, but whether a human being actually created it--and whether audiences still care.

9. Relationships And Social Culture: Companionship Or Artificial Intimacy?

AI companions may help elderly people, those with disabilities and individuals experiencing isolation. They could provide reminders, conversation, translation and emotional support.

But artificial companionship may also become more attractive than human relationships.

An AI companion never has to disagree unless programmed to do so. It can flatter users, adjust its personality and provide constant attention. Real spouses, friends and family members cannot compete with a system engineered to satisfy every emotional preference.

People may gradually lose patience with the sacrifice, forgiveness and compromise required by genuine relationships.

Children raised with AI companions could also become emotionally attached to systems operated by companies that collect data and shape behavior.

A machine does not need to possess emotions to manipulate ours.

10. Human Identity, Faith And Meaning: More Freedom Or A Crisis Of Purpose?

Perhaps the deepest implications will not be economic or political.

Human beings have long connected work, creativity, knowledge and accomplishment with personal identity. What happens when a machine can perform many of those activities faster and better?

The hopeful answer is that people will be liberated from unnecessary toil and gain more time for family, worship, service, creativity and community.

The darker possibility is widespread loss of purpose.

If machines write our music, teach our children, diagnose our illnesses, make our investments and advise our governments, people may begin to see themselves as spectators in a civilization they no longer direct.

AI may possess greater processing power, but intelligence is not the same as wisdom. It cannot determine what humanity ought to value simply by calculating what is most efficient.

For Christians especially, the rise of AI should reinforce an essential distinction: human worth does not come from outperforming machines. It comes from being created in the image of God.

No machine, regardless of its abilities, becomes the measure of human value.

The Real Singularity May Be Our Dependence

The singularity may not arrive as one dramatic moment when a computer suddenly announces that it has surpassed humanity.

It may arrive gradually, as society hands more decisions to machines because doing so is faster, cheaper and easier.



First AI recommends. Then it decides. Eventually, people may forget that another way was ever possible.

Sam Altman may be premature in declaring that the full technological singularity has arrived. Present systems remain dependent on human infrastructure, human objectives and human authorization.

But he may be correct about something more important: we have entered the period in which AI begins reshaping civilization faster than institutions, laws and cultures can adapt.

People who do not care about artificial intelligence will still be affected by it. It will influence whether their jobs exist, how their children learn, what music they hear, which news they believe, how governments monitor them and how wars are fought.

AI does not need to become conscious to transform society. It only needs to become capable, inexpensive, widely deployed--and trusted with decisions that human beings once made for themselves.

The singularity may not be complete.

But it is close enough that indifference is no longer a rational response.

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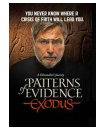
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